

American Political Divides and Great Debates

[84-309] | Fall 2026

Prof. Jonathan Cervas

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The most up-to-date version of this **syllabus can be found here**: <https://jcervas.github.io/teaching/2026-2027/class-cmu-2026-84-309/readme.html>

Course Relevance: DC: Perspectives on Justice and Injustice

Learning Resources: All resources will be provided via Canvas

Prerequisites: NONE

August

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September

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October

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November

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December

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■ in person

 remote

 no class

01 Course Description

Are Americans really so divided? The question sounds rhetorical, but political scientists have spent thirty years disagreeing about the answer, and the first month of this course works through that argument: whether the public has genuinely polarized or merely sorted itself into tidier parties, what people mean by “affective polarization” and whether it does the damage commonly attributed to it, how race and partisanship reinforce one another, and whether any of this actually threatens democracy. You will read scholars arguing with each other in print, sometimes over the same data.

The rest of the semester belongs to you. Working in teams of four or five, you will choose a topic, assign your classmates the readings, set the questions, and run the discussion yourselves. Alongside that you will write an op-ed for a general audience, review a book and present it to the class, and build a policy brief with a small team.

Running through all of it is a question about justice: how political division creates and entrenches inequality — who gets heard, who gets represented, and who absorbs the costs of a politics organized around mutual dislike. No previous coursework in political science is expected, and no statistics beyond reading a chart.

02 Learning Objectives

By the end of this course, students will be able to:

1. **Explain** what political scientists have actually established about polarization in the United States, and identify where they still disagree.
2. **Distinguish** ideological polarization, partisan sorting, affective polarization, and negative partisanship, and weigh the evidence offered for each.
3. **Analyze** how political divisions intersect with and reinforce racial, economic, and social inequality.
4. **Evaluate** competing arguments on contested questions — including the argument you disagree with, in its strongest form.
5. **Facilitate** informed discussion: select readings, frame questions that have no easy answer, and moderate disagreement without flattening it.
6. **Communicate** persuasively to a general audience, in writing and aloud.
7. **Develop** evidence-based policy recommendations and account for their consequences for equity.
8. **Reflect** on your own values, biases, and role as a civic participant in a divided society.

03 Assessment

The course grade will be a weighted average of the following components:

Assignment	Percent of Final Grade
Attendance	25%
Discussion Board (before each class)	15%
Student Led Topics	9%
Surveys (3: intake, midterm, evaluation)	2%
Book Review (Slides + Presentation)	12%
Op-Ed Project (Draft + Review + Final)	20%
Group Policy Brief	17%

04 Due Dates

Assignment	Due Date
Discussion board post	9:00 a.m., each class day
Surveys (3)	August 26, October 7, final week
Op-ed, first draft	September 21
Op-ed peer review	September 24
Op-ed final draft	September 28
Book Review (slides)	November 23
Group Project	December 1/3
Group Project reflection	December 4

05 Assignment Details

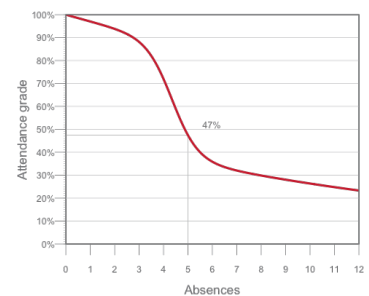
Attendance (25%)

Purpose: Civic discourse, empathy, critical thinking

Objective Alignment: 4, 8

Showing up is the assignment. This grade covers both being here and being present once you are — arriving prepared (having completed the readings) and contributing thoughtfully and respectfully to discussion.

Regular attendance and active involvement form a significant part of your final grade (see grading section). If you do not show up, you will not earn an 'A'. To recognize that occasional absences are sometimes unavoidable (e.g., for religious observance, job interviews, university-sanctioned events, or illness), attendance grades follow a curve with three stretches. The first three absences cost you almost nothing — that is what they are there for. From the fourth to the sixth the penalty bites hard, and this is the range where a semester goes wrong. After that the curve flattens into a long tail: each further absence still costs you, but less, and it never reaches zero. There is no point at which you may as well stop coming.



Absences and the attendance grade. The first three cost almost nothing; four to six is where it bites.

Absences	0	2	3	4	5	6	8	12
Attendance grade	100%	94%	88%	72%	47%	36%	30%	23%

If you must miss class, please notify the TA (and cc the professor) at least 24 hours in advance (unless it is an emergency or sudden illness) so we can arrange a way for you to catch up.¹

Devices. Laptops, tablets, and phones are not to be used for anything that is not pertinent to what we are doing in the room. The simplest version of this: keep them in your bag. If you are found using a device for something unrelated to class, **you will be marked absent for that session** — see the curve above for what that costs.

This is not about distraction alone. This course runs on discussion, and a room where half the screens are open is a room where people are performing attention rather than paying it. You will also be asked, repeatedly, to sit with an argument you dislike before responding to it; a device is the easiest available exit from that discomfort, and taking the exit is how you learn nothing.

If you have an accommodation from the Office of Disability Resources that involves a device, it governs — bring me your letter and this policy does not apply to you.

Discussion Board (15%)

Purpose: Arriving with your thinking already underway

Objective Alignment: 1, 4, 8

Before every class meeting you post at least one comment to the course discussion board — **every meeting, including the one your own team leads**. There are 21 boards, one for each class that has one. Posts are due by **9:00 a.m. on the day we meet**, which gives me time to read the room before I walk into it — and gives you a reason to have opened the reading before the hour it is discussed.

Either raise something or answer someone. A post counts if it does one of two things: it puts a question on the table, or it responds to a question or comment a classmate has already put there. Both are worth the same. A thread where nobody replies is just a stack of monologues, and a thread where nobody asks anything runs out of road — the board needs both, and you can supply either.

Keep it short. A few sentences is plenty; there is no length requirement and no credit for padding. What matters is that you have put something down before the conversation starts.

The board is only ever used before a class, never after it. Every board belongs to one session and closes when that session begins; nothing is posted to it afterwards, and no assignment in this course asks you to write up a class once it has happened. The one piece of writing that does look backwards — the student-led reflection above — goes in Canvas under Assignments, in the days after your team leads.

What to raise, or what to answer, depends on the day.

¹ If you need to miss more than two sessions due to extenuating circumstances, let me know as soon as possible so we can discuss how best to support you.

- **When a student team is leading.** That team posts its five or six questions to the board three days before. **Everyone not on that team either answers one of them or puts a further question on the table** — if you are answering, say which question you are taking, so the thread stays legible. These are the days the board does the most work, because the leaders walk in already knowing where the room stands.
 - **If it is your team leading, your questions are your post for that day.** You do not owe a second comment on top of them, and you are credited for the board that day like everyone else. Replying to your classmates' answers before class is worth doing, but it is not required.
- **When the day has an assigned reading,** respond to it: what you found unconvincing, where two readings collide, a question they raise and do not answer.
- **Otherwise, the floor is open.** Post what is actually on your mind — something in the news, something from an earlier session you are still chewing on, a question you did not get to ask out loud. Not every class needs a set topic for you to have something worth saying.

Grading. Completion and engagement, not correctness. Every post is worth the same, and they simply add up: there are 21 across the semester, so each one is worth a little under five percent of the board grade. Miss one and you lose that much; miss five and you have lost about a quarter of it. Nothing is forgiven automatically and nothing accelerates — the arithmetic is the whole policy, and you can work out where you stand at any point in the term from your own record in Canvas.

Your two lowest scores are dropped, automatically and without your asking. A bad week, an illness, a day you simply forgot — two of those cost you nothing, and you never have to explain them to me. Past that, the arithmetic above applies.

The board is visible to everyone in the class. That is the point; it lets a discussion open already in motion instead of from a standing start, and it means the quiet half of the room has said something before anyone speaks aloud. But be clear-eyed about what a board is. Unlike what we say aloud in this room, a post is written down, attached to your name, and takes one keystroke to capture. I cannot stop anyone from screenshotting it and I am not going to pretend otherwise. Write accordingly: say what you actually think, and assume it could travel.

Student Led Topics (9%)

Purpose: Facilitation, synthesis, reflection

Objective Alignment: 2, 4, 5, 6

You will run a class. Not present to one, run it.

Working in a team of four or five, you choose a topic connected to the course themes, assign the readings your classmates will do beforehand, and lead the session. Teams and topics are set on September 1, and the calendar of who leads which day is fixed that week and does not move.

What your team owes the class. The topic and readings are due five days before you lead; the questions go up three days before:

1. **A topic.** Narrow enough to argue about in eighty minutes. “Immigration” is not a topic; “whether birthright citizenship can be altered by executive order” is.
2. **The readings.** Two or three pieces, and no more than about sixty pages total. They must not all argue the same side. Post them to Canvas five days ahead so your classmates can actually read them. A reading posted late is a session that falls flat, and the whole class pays for it. Ideally, multiple points of view are reflected in the readings.
3. **Discussion questions.** Five or six, written out, **posted to your session’s discussion board** three days before you lead, so the class arrives having answered them. Good ones have no obvious answer and cannot be resolved by looking something up.
 - **This is how the board works on your day, and it is different for you than for everyone else.** Posting these questions is your discussion-board contribution for the session you lead — you owe nothing further, and you are credited for that board like the rest of the class. Everyone not on your team then either answers one of your questions or raises another, before the hour. Nobody posts to a board after the class it belongs to. The full rule is under **Discussion Board** above.

On the day your team runs the room: open the question, keep the conversation moving, pull in people who have not spoken, and cut off a thread that has stopped going anywhere. I will be there and will step in if needed, but the session is yours.

Within three days of the session you lead, a short written reflection — written while it is still fresh, not saved up for the end of term. How did the discussion actually go? Where did it stall, and what would you do differently if you ran it again? What have you taken from the sessions your classmates have led so far? It goes in **Canvas under Assignments**, never on the discussion board, and your team’s deadline is fixed with the leading calendar on September 1.

A note on the readings: the strongest sessions in past years have not all been academic articles. A podcast episode, a documentary segment, an op-ed pair from opposing outlets, or a piece of data journalism can carry a discussion as well as a scholarly paper — often better. Vary the voices you assign.

Surveys (2%)

Purpose: Getting to know you, your goals, and what is working in the course

Objective Alignment: 8

Three short surveys: first week, midpoint, final week. The first is the **Cervas Election Study**, modelled on the Cooperative Election Study; the second is course feedback, early enough that I can still act on it; the third is an end-of-course evaluation. Links are in **Canvas, under Assignments**.

The first ends with eight questions asking you to estimate what the two parties are made of — how many Democrats are union members, how many Republicans earn over \$250,000. Answer cold: nothing looked up, nothing compared with a classmate. Your answers become a class dataset, which I report back only in aggregate, and we set it beside the published figures on September 8.

Graded for completion, not content; the estimates are not graded on accuracy, and being wrong is the finding. The survey is anonymous and cannot tell me you finished it, so **screenshot the confirmation screen and upload it to the Canvas assignment** — the screenshot is your receipt.

Book Review Assignment (12%)

Purpose: Deep analysis, critical evaluation, communication

Objective Alignment: 1, 2, 4, 6

- **Slide Deck (5%)**

Purpose: Argument analysis, assumption critique, implication discussion

- *Length:* **No fewer than 5 slides and no more than 10**, excluding a title slide and any references slide.
- *Content Guidelines:*
 - Summarize the author's central argument(s) succinctly.
 - Critically evaluate those arguments using logical reasoning and textual evidence.
 - Identify any assumptions or ideological lenses the author brings.
 - Discuss broader political, ethical, or social implications.
 - Make connections to course themes such as inequality, polarization, or justice.
 - Cite anything you quote or paraphrase.
- *On slide design:* a slide is not a page. Put one idea on each, in words large enough to read from the back of the room, and let the rest live in what you say. A deck of dense paragraphs read aloud is the failure mode this assignment is built to avoid. Ten sparse slides beat five crowded ones, and the ceiling is there to stop the deck from becoming the paper.
- **In-Class Oral Presentation (7%)**

Purpose: Verbal synthesis, peer engagement, clarity of thought

Format: Short oral presentation, followed by discussion

- **You present to a small group, not to the whole class.** On November 24 everyone presents in the same session: you will be placed in a breakout group of five or six and present there, about ten minutes each including questions. I move between groups. The grade is the same as it would be in front of everyone.
- *Expectations:*
 - Clear, engaging summary of key ideas from the book.
 - Highlight your critical take or most interesting insight.
 - Open the floor by posing a question or provocation, and field your classmates' responses.
 - Speak to your slides rather than reading them; the presentation is assessed on delivery and engagement, not on narrating the deck.

Op-ed w/ peer-review (20%)

Purpose: Persuasive writing, revision, public engagement

Objective Alignment: 3, 6, 7

- Drawing on a topic related to this course, or something political from your own life or experience, write an op-ed that could be published in a newspaper or blog.

The weight sits where the work is. Writing the thing and reading someone else's carefully are the hard parts; the final draft is where you carry out edits you have already been handed.

- **Rough Draft (10%)**

- *Length:* There is a strict 1,250-word limit.
- *Content Guidelines:*
 - * Prepare a short essay advocating for (or against) any social or political issue of your choosing.
 - * The idea is that you will write something that can be submitted to a newspaper or internet blog.
 - * Concise arguments made for a more general audience are the goal of this assignment; something your parents can read and understand.
 - * The use of data and visualizations is strongly encouraged and is not included in the word count.
- Graded as a finished piece, not as a sketch. Hand in something you would be willing to see published — a draft written to be fixed later is worth very little to the classmate who has to review it.
- **This deadline is hard, and it is the one deadline in the course with no exceptions.** A late draft costs **10% immediately, and a further 1% for every hour after that.** Unlike everything else in this course, it can reach zero.
- The reason is not severity for its own sake. Two classmates are assigned to read you, and when review assignments go out, whatever exists is what they get. If your draft is not there, they are given someone else's instead, the class is not held up waiting for you. But you go into your final draft without the feedback everyone else received, you still owe the two reviews you were assigned, and the points are gone. The cost of being late lands on you, which is exactly where it belongs.

- **Peer Review (8%)**

- You will review two classmates' drafts. This is worth nearly as much as writing your own, and is graded on the quality of what you give them.
- Address the substance first, then the prose: Is the thesis clear, and is it stated early enough? Is the evidence convincing? Would a reader outside this class follow it? Where does it lose momentum?
- Say the useful thing. "Nice job" is not a review; naming the paragraph where the argument stops working is.

- **Final Draft (2%)**

- Carry out the revisions your reviewers identified, and improve anything else you now see. This is assessed on whether you took the feedback seriously — what changed, and why — rather than re-graded as a fresh piece of writing.

- If you disagree with a reviewer, you are free to leave it as it was; note briefly why, and that counts as taking it seriously.

Group Policy Brief (17%)

Purpose: Research, equity-centered solutions, teamwork *Objective Alignment:* 3, 7, 8

- **Written Brief (10%):** Small teams choose a politically polarizing issue tied to inequality (e.g., gerrymandering, Medicaid expansion, tech bias) and write a formal policy brief (~1,500–2,000 words).
 - *Components:*
 - * Executive Summary
 - * Problem Definition
 - * Background/Context
 - * Policy Options & Stakeholder Analysis
 - * Recommendation(s)
 - * Equity Impact Statement
- **Presentation (5%):** Teams present findings in a mock legislative or community forum during finals week.
- **Individual Reflection (2%):** A short piece, submitted on your own after your team presents, on how the work actually went.
 - *Address:*
 - * What you personally contributed – specific tasks, sections, and decisions, not “I helped with research.”
 - * What each teammate contributed, in the same concrete terms.
 - * How the team divided work, and whether that division held up.
 - * What you would do differently on a team project next time.
 - Submitted individually and read only by the instructors. Your teammates never see it.
 - **These evaluations can move your grade.** Where the reflections from a team agree that contribution was substantially uneven, I may adjust individual grades on the brief and the presentation above or below the team grade. A team that divided the work fairly sees no adjustment, which is the ordinary outcome.
 - Be candid in both directions. Credit is easy to overlook, and a teammate who carried more than their share should be named. If the load was uneven, say so plainly – a group grade that lands identically on someone who did the work and someone who did not is its own kind of unfairness, and this is how I find out.

06 Grading

Your grade depends heavily on active engagement. This course is interactive: your preparation (completing the readings), contributions to discussions, and participation in debates are essential to your success.

Assignments & Deadlines You are expected to meet all assignment deadlines. If you anticipate being unable to turn something in on time, contact me before the due date to discuss alternatives. Late work will incur a penalty² provided it does not impede your classmates' progress (for instance, in group projects). Failing to participate or contribute meaningfully, especially in ways that affect others' work, will result in a lower grade.

² One percentage point per hour late, never falling below 50%. An hour or two costs almost nothing; a day costs a letter grade, but late work is always worth more than no work. Work never submitted scores zero, so handing something in a week late is always worth more than handing in nothing. Canvas applies both automatically.

07 Schedule

Week 1 – the course, and the Fence

- **Tue, Aug 25** – Introduction to the Course
 - Nothing is settled today: teams and topics are fixed on **Sep 1**.
 - **DUE Wed, Aug 26, 11:59 p.m.** – the **Cervas Election Study** (link in Canvas; screenshot the confirmation).
- **Thu, Aug 27** – The Fence
 - **In class: the Perception Gap.** More in Common, perceptiongap.us.
 - Background on “The Fence”
 - “CMU Fence Controversy Sparks Censorship Concerns.” Pittsburgh...
 - Strasburg et al. 2025 – In Midnight Move, CMU Students Roll in...
 - Chang et al. 2026 – YAL Rallies at Fence, Delivers Petition to...
 - Aiken 2026 – Carnegie Mellon Investigating Students over Fence...
 - Articles from The Tartan on the Fence's history
 - Student Handbook, Advertising on Campus
 - Student Government Graffiti and Poster Policy

Week 2 – Polarization unit opens

- **Tue, Sep 1** – Organize Topics for Student Led Discussions
- **Thu, Sep 3** – Polarization I: Partisan and Ideological Polarization
 - Fiorina et al. 2008 – Political Polarization in the American...
 - Abramowitz et al. 2008 – Is Polarization a Myth?
 - Fiorina 2024 – Once More Unto the Breach: Is America Polarized?
 - *Optional:* Fiorina 2026 – *Unstable Majorities Continue: The Trump Era*
 - *Optional:* McCarty, Nolan, Keith T. Poole, and Howard Rosenthal. Polarized America: The Dance of Ideo

Week 3 – Polarization unit

- **Tue, Sep 8** – Polarization II: Sorting and Social Identity
 - Mason 2015 – ‘I Disrespectfully Agree’
 - Ahler et al. 2018 – The Parties in Our Heads
 - *Optional:* Mason 2018 – *Uncivil Agreement

- **Thu, Sep 10** — Polarization III: Affective Polarization
 - Iyengar et al. 2019 — The Origins and Consequences of Affective...
 - Finkel et al. 2020 — Political Sectarianism in America
 - Fiorina 2024 — What About *Affective Polarization*?
 - *Optional*: Klar et al. 2018 — Affective Polarization or Partisan Disdain?...
 - *Optional*: Broockman et al. 2023 — Does Affective Polarization Undermine...

Week 4 — NO CLASS (Sep 15–17)

- **Tue, Sep 15** — **NO CLASS**. Eradicate Hate Conference.
- **Thu, Sep 17** — **NO CLASS**. Constitution Day Symposium.

Week 5 — Polarization unit

- **Tue, Sep 22** — Polarization IV: Negative Partisanship and the White Working Class
 - Abramowitz et al. 2016 — The Rise of Negative Partisanship and...
 - Abramowitz 2025 — It's Not the Economy, Stupid
 - Fiorina 2024 — The White Working Class
 - *Optional*: Iyengar et al. 2015 — Fear and Loathing across Party Lines
 - *Optional*: Fiorina 2024 — Economic Anxiety or Cultural Backlash
 - *Optional*: Abramowitz et al. 2018 — Negative Partisanship
- **Thu, Sep 24** — Polarization V: Race and Polarization
 - Tesler 2012 — The Spillover of Racialization into Health Care
 - Mason et al. 2021 — Activating Animus
 - *Optional*: Jardina 2019 — *White Identity Politics*
 - *Optional*: Voelkel et al. 2024 — Megastudy Testing 25 Treatments to Reduce...
 - *Optional*: Kleinfeld 2023 — *Polarization, Democracy, and Political...

Week 6 — Polarization unit • geography

- **Tue, Sep 29** — Polarization VII: Geographic — The Map, and the Power in It
 - **Do these before you read anything.**
 - Brown, Jacob R., and Ryan D. Enos. "Partisan Segregation."...
 - The New York Times 2025 — An Extremely Detailed Map of the 2024...
 - Badger et al. 2021 — A Close-Up Picture of Partisan...
 - Brown et al. 2026 — How Generational Turnover and Party...
 - De Witte 2019 — How the Urban-Rural Divide Shapes Elections
 - Cervas 2026 — The Effects of Mid-Decade Redistricting on...
 - *Optional*: Abrams et al. 2012 — 'The Big Sort' That Wasn't
 - *Optional*: Chen et al. 2015 — Cutting Through the Thicket
 - *Optional*: "How the Other Half Votes
 - *Optional*: Petry, Eric. "How the Efficiency Gap Works." Brennan Center for...
 - *Optional*: Kenny et al. 2023 — Widespread Partisan Gerrymandering Mostly...
 - *Optional*: Brown et al. 2026 — Partisan Sorting and Geographic Polarization

- *Optional*: Brown et al. 2021 – The Measurement of Partisan Sorting for 180...
- *Optional*: Mummolo et al. 2017 – Why Partisans Do Not Sort
- *Optional*: Brown 2025 – Partisan Conversion Through Neighborhood Influence
- *Optional*: Scala et al. 2017 – Political Polarization along the...
- *Optional*: Chen et al. 2013 – Unintentional Gerrymandering
- *Optional*: Cervas et al. 2020 – Tools for Identifying Partisan...
- *Optional*: Goedert 2014 – Gerrymandering or Geography? How Democrats Won...
- *Optional*: Riccardi 2026 – Redistricting War Accelerates Winner-Take-All...
- *Optional*: Levitsky et al. 2023 – *Tyranny of the Minority
- *Optional*: Cervas et al. 2020 – Legal, Political Science and Economics...
- **Thu, Oct 1** – Place, Identity, and Rural Consciousness
 - **Two chapters, and that is the whole assignment.** Jacobs and Shea fielded the largest survey ever taken of rural Americans, and the book that came out of it is the best available answer to
 - Jacobs et al. 2023 – *The Rural Voter
 - *Optional*: Harper 2024 – An Utterly Misleading Book About Rural America
 - *Optional*: Jacobs et al. 2024 – The Truth About ‘Rural Rage’
 - *Optional*: Schaller et al. 2024 – An Honest Assessment of Rural White...
 - *Optional*: Cramer 2016 – *The Politics of Resentment
 - *Optional*: Lunz Trujillo et al. 2022
 - *Optional*: Nelsen et al. 2021 – Race and White Rural Consciousness
 - *Optional*: Jacobs et al. 2023 – Place-Based Resentment in Contemporary U
 - *Optional*: Lunz Trujillo 2024 – Feeling Out of Place
 - *Optional*: Hershewe et al. 2025 – When Politics Override Place
 - *Optional*: Geismer 2024 – A New Suburban Politics

Week 7 – Polarization unit closes

- **Tue, Oct 6** – Polarization VI: Does Any of This Threaten Democracy?
 - Druckman et al. 2023 – Does Affective Polarization Contribute...
 - McCoy et al. 2019 – Toward a Theory of Pernicious Polarization...
 - “Would You Vote Against Your Own Side to Save Democracy?”
 - Graham et al. 2020 – Democracy in America? Partisanship,...
- **Thu, Oct 8** – Who Pays for the News?
 - Darr et al. 2018 – Newspaper Closures Polarize Voting Behavior
 - Martin et al. 2019 – Local News and National Politics
 - Pickard 2020 – Restructuring Democratic Infrastructures

Week 8 – FALL BREAK, no class (Oct 13–15)

- **Tue, Oct 13** – **NO CLASS.** Fall Break.
- **Thu, Oct 15** – **NO CLASS.** Fall Break.

Week 9 – Student-led sessions open

- **Tue, Oct 20** – Student-led session – team and topic TBA
- **Thu, Oct 22** – Student-led session – team and topic TBA

Week 10 – Student-led • before the vote

- **Tue, Oct 27** – Before the Vote: Loser's Consent
 - Layman et al. 2023 – Political Parties and Loser's Consent in...
- **Thu, Oct 29** – Student-led session – team and topic TBA

Week 11 – Student-led • election week

- **Tue, Nov 3** – **NO CLASS.** Democracy Day; the midterm elections. No classes before 5 p.m. Register to vote.
- **Thu, Nov 5** – Student-led session – team and topic TBA

Week 12 – Student-led

- **Tue, Nov 10** – Student-led session – team and topic TBA
- **Thu, Nov 12** – Student-led session – team and topic TBA

Week 13 – Student-led

- **Tue, Nov 17** – Student-led session – team and topic TBA
- **Thu, Nov 19** – Student-led session – team and topic TBA

Week 14 – Book review presentations

- **Tue, Nov 24** – VIRTUAL CLASS – Book Review Presentations
 - **Everyone presents today.** You will not present to the room – you will be put into a small breakout group and present there, which is how thirty-four presentations fit into eighty minutes.
 - Slides are due Mon, Nov 23 at 11:59 p.m., uploaded to Canvas.
 - Speak to your slides rather than reading them, and open the floor with a question. A group
 - Being in a small group does not make this informal. It is the same 7% it would be in front
- **Thu, Nov 26** – **NO CLASS.** Thanksgiving.

Week 15 – Group policy briefs

- **Tue, Dec 1** – Group Policy Brief
- **Thu, Dec 3** – Group Policy Brief

08 Units on the shelf

Short free substitutes

- De Witte, Melissa. 2019. "How the Urban-Rural Divide Shapes Elections." Stanford Report. — **six minutes**, Q&A with Rodden, no jargon. The best short thing in existence on this topic; delivers the whole "Democrats win cities by huge margins and lose everywhere else narrowly" mechanism.
 - <https://news.stanford.edu/stories/2019/06/urban-rural-divide-sha...>
- Pew Research Center. 2024. "Partisanship in Rural, Suburban and Urban Communities." — eight minutes, two charts. Rural R+25, up from R+6 in 2000; urban 60–37 Democratic; suburbs 50–47.
 - <https://www.pewresearch.org/politics/2024/04/09/partisanship-in-...>
- Rodden, Jonathan, and Will Wilkinson. 2019. "Explaining the Urban-Rural Political Divide." Niskanen Center. — podcast with full transcript; skim in fifteen minutes. Two scholars who agree about the map and disagree about why: Rodden says nineteenth-century rail and factory geography, Wilkinson says contemporary personality self-selection.
 - <https://www.niskanencenter.org/explaining-the-urban-rural-politi...>
- Hennig, Benjamin. 2024. "Cartographic Perspectives of the 2024 U.S. Election." *Election Analysis*. — ten minutes, free. Population-weighted cartograms. The best short piece on how the standard county map lies about American political geography, and a good thing to open a session with.
 - <https://www.electionanalysis.ws/us/president2024/section-3-voter...>
- Muro, Mark, and Shriya Methkupal. 2024. "Trump Again Won Counties Representing a Minority Share of National GDP, but with Notable Gains." Brookings, November 8. — ten minutes. Trump won 86% of counties producing 38% of GDP. Trump-won counties in the top 100 by GDP went from 5 to 16, including Maricopa, Miami-Dade and Tarrant.
 - <https://www.brookings.edu/articles/trump-again-won-counties-repr...>

Assembled and ready to schedule, but not currently on the calendar. Any of these can be dropped into an open session, or handed to a student team as a starting point for their own.

America's Founding: Enlightened or Enslaved?

America's Founding: Enlightened or Enslaved?

1. *The 1619 Project*

- "America Wasn't a Democracy Until Black Americans Made It One" – Essay by Nikole Hannah-Jones <https://www.nytimes.com/interactive/2019/08/14/magazine/black-hi...>

- Introduces the central thesis of the project: re-centering slavery and Black Americans in the nation's founding narrative.
- "In Order to Understand the Brutality of American Capitalism, You Have to Start on the Plantation" – Essay by Matthew Desmond
<https://www.nytimes.com/interactive/2019/08/14/magazine/slavery-...>
- Connects slavery to contemporary economic systems.

2. *The 1776 Report*

– Arnn, Larry P., Carol Swain, and Matthew Spalding. 2021. *The...* – Presents a traditionalist, patriotic framing of American founding values.

Optional Readings

1. *_The 1776 Report_*

- "AHA Statement Condemning Report of Advisory 1776 Commission."
* [\[https://www.historians.org/news/aha-statement-condemning-report-...\]](https://www.historians.org/news/aha-statement-condemning-report-...) (<https://www.historians.org/news>)
- McKenna, Konstantin. 2025. "The 1776 Project Is a Desperate Search for the Right Enemies." *Foreign Policy*.
* [\[https://foreignpolicy.com/2021/01/21/1776-project-desperate-sear...\]](https://foreignpolicy.com/2021/01/21/1776-project-desperate-sear...) (<https://foreignpolicy.com/2021/01/21/1776-project-desperate-sear...>)

2. *_The 1619 Project_*

- Hannah-Jones, Nikole. 2019. *The 1619 Project*. The New York Times Magazine.
* [\[https://pulitzercenter.org/sites/default/files/full_issue_of_the...\]](https://pulitzercenter.org/sites/default/files/full_issue_of_the...) (https://pulitzercenter.org/sites/default/files/full_issue_of_the...)
- Silverstein, Jake. 2020. "On Recent Criticism of The 1619 Project." The New York Times.
* [\[https://www.nytimes.com/2020/10/16/magazine/criticism-1619-proje...\]](https://www.nytimes.com/2020/10/16/magazine/criticism-1619-proje...) (<https://www.nytimes.com/2020/10/16/magazine/criticism-1619-proje...>)
- "We Respond to the Historians Who Critiqued The 1619 Project." 2019. The New York Times.
* [\[https://www.nytimes.com/2019/12/20/magazine/we-respond-to-the-hi...\]](https://www.nytimes.com/2019/12/20/magazine/we-respond-to-the-hi...) (<https://www.nytimes.com/2019/12/20/magazine/we-respond-to-the-hi...>)

3. ****Optional for ambitious students****

- Frederick Douglass, "What to the Slave is the Fourth of July?" (1852)
* (~20 min read, historical context for both projects)

Free Speech and Academic Freedom on Campus

Free Speech in Schools

- Chemerinsky, Erwin. 2024. "The Underlying Issues Concerning Free Speech in Schools." *Stanford Law Review* 76: 1427.
- <https://review.law.stanford.edu/wp-content/uploads/sites/3/2024/...>

Introduction and the History of Free Speech in America

- Chemerinsky, Erwin, and Howard Gillman. 2018. *Free speech on campus*. Paperback edition. New Haven ; London: Yale University Press.
 - Chapter 1: The New Censorship
 - Chapter 2: Why Is Free Speech Important? **The History of Academic Freedom**

- Chemerinsky, Erwin, and Howard Gillman. 2018. Free speech on campus. Paperback edition. New Haven; London: Yale University Press.
 - Chapter 3: Nullius in Verba: Free Speech at Colleges and Universities
 - Chapter 4: Hate Speech
 - Chapter 5: What Campuses Can and Can't Do
 - Chapter 6: What's at Stake? (short)

Racism in Policing

Racism in Policing

- Bangs, R. "Pittsburgh's Massive Racial Disparities in Police Actions, 2021-2023" July 1, 2024.
 - Op-Ed Link:...
- Bangs, R. "Police Discrimination Against Black Youth Under Age 18" October 1, 2024.
 - Op-Ed Link:...

Optional: - Bangs, R. "Fourth Amendment Problems with Pittsburgh Police Policies" February 2025 * <https://www.crsp.pitt.edu/fourth-amendment-problems-pittsburgh-p...> - Bangs, R. "Pittsburgh Leaders Must Recognize the Serious Racial Problems in Police Actions" January 2025 * <https://live-racesocialproblems-pitt.pantheonsite.io/pittsburgh-...> - Bangs, R. "Racial Disparities and Discrimination in Drug Arrest Charges by Pittsburgh Police, January-October 2022" November 2024 * <https://www.crsp.pitt.edu/racial-disparities-and-discrimination-...> - Bangs, R. "New National Reports on Anti-Black Pretextual Traffic Stops and Frisks, Related Pittsburgh Police Data, and Recommendations" October 15, 2024 * <https://www.crsp.pitt.edu/new-national-reports-anti-black-pretex...>

Ezra Klein, *Why We're Polarized*

- Klein, Ezra. 2020. *Why We're Polarized*. Avid Reader Press / Simon & Schuster. **Available from CMU Library, and used at many bookstores. Working on making it available on Canvas.**
 - https://cmu.primo.exlibrisgroup.com/permalink/01CMU_INST/6lpsnm/...
- Klein, Introduction: What Didn't Happen
- Klein, Chapter 1: How Democrats Became Liberals and Republicans Became Conservatives
- Klein, Chapter 2: The Dixiecrat Dilemma
- Klein, Chapter 3: Your Brain on Groups
- Klein, Chapter 4: The Press Secretary in Your Mind
- Klein, Chapter 5: Demographic Threat
- Klein, Chapter 6: The Media Divide beyond Left-Right
- Klein, Chapter 7: Post-Persuasion Elections
- Klein, Chapter 8: When Bipartisanship Becomes Irrational
- Klein, Chapter 9: The Difference between Democrats and Republicans
- Klein, Chapter 10: Managing Polarization—and Ourselves

The Internet and Social Media

The Internet and Social Media

- Larreguy, Horacio, and Pia J. Raffler. 2025. "Accountability in Developing Democracies: The Impact of the Internet, Social Media, and Polarization." *Annual Review of Political Science* 28(Volume 28, 2025): 413–434.
 - <https://www.annualreviews.org/content/journals/10.1146/annurev-p...>
- Barrett, Paul, Justin Hendrix, and Grant Sims. 2021. *Fueling the Fire: How Social Media Intensifies U.S. Political Polarization And What Can Be Done About It*. NYU Stern Center for Business and Human Rights.
 - <https://bhr.stern.nyu.edu/wp-content/uploads/2024/02/NYUCBHRFuel...>
- Shapiro, Ari. 2022. "How the polarizing effect of social media is speeding up." NPR.
 - <https://www.npr.org/2022/09/09/1121295499/facebook-twitter-youtu...>

Identity Politics and Polarization

Identity Politics and Polarization

- Iyengar, Shanto. 2025. "Identity Politics, Party Polarization, and the Rise of Donald Trump." In *The Changing Character of the American Right, Volume I: Ideology, Politics and Policy in the Era of Trump*, eds. Joel D. Aberbach et al. Cham: Springer Nature Switzerland, p. 79–94.
 - https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-031-73168-6_4

Academic Freedom (Rabban)

Academic Freedom

- Rabban, David M. "Academic Freedom"
 - Introduction: <https://canvas.cmu.edu/courses/47827/files/folder/Academic%20Freedom?preview=13401305>
 - Chapter 11 - Student Academic Freedom: <https://canvas.cmu.edu/courses/47827/files/folder/Academic%20Freedom?preview=13401306>

09 Potential topics for Student Led Discussions

- **"Democracy" and "America" are not the same word.** When people say polarization threatens democracy, some mean the procedures — elections, courts, the peaceful transfer — and some mean the country, its identity and who counts as a real American. The two arguments are often run together and they have different evidence behind them. Pulling them apart is a session on its own, and it bears directly on Oct 6.

Topic banks assembled in previous semesters. Students leading a session are welcome to draw on these, or to propose readings of their own.

Immigration Politics

- <https://www.whitehouse.gov/presidential-actions/2025/01/protecting-the-american-people-against-invasion/>
- <https://www.cfr.org/backgrounder/us-immigration-debate-0>
- Politico: Former ICE Director Q&A
- Reason: Immigration and Freedom
- *Optional:* RSF Journal: Immigration Study (PDF)

Affirmative Action (STUDENTS FOR FAIR ADMISSIONS, INC. v. PRESIDENT AND FELLOWS OF HARVARD COLLEGE, No. 20-1199) – Decided June 29, 2023

- Opinion of the Court
 - ROBERTS, C. J., delivered the opinion of the Court, in which THOMAS, ALITO, GORSUCH, KAVANAUGH, and BARRETT, JJ., joined.
 - * https://www.supremecourt.gov/opinions/22pdf/20-1199_hgdj.pdf
- Dissent
 - SOTOMAYOR, J., filed a dissenting opinion, in which KAGAN, J., joined, and in which JACKSON, J., joined as it applies to No. 21-707.
- Concurring & other Dissenting Opinions
 - THOMAS, J., filed a concurring opinion.
 - GORSUCH, J., filed a concurring opinion, in which THOMAS, J., joined.
 - KAVANAUGH, J., filed a concurring opinion.
 - JACKSON, J., filed a dissenting opinion in No. 21-707, in which SOTOMAYOR and KAGAN, JJ., joined.
- Background and commentary
 - History of Affirmative Action
 - Pew Research: Topic – Affirmative Action in College Admissions...
 - The Strange Career of Affirmative Action – Harvard Scholars
 - Affirmative Action Article (Pro)
 - Penn Carey Law: The Case for Affirmative Action (Pro)
 - NAACP: Affirmative Action in Education Matters (Pro)
 - Harvard GSE: The Case for Affirmative Action (Pro Case)
 - Affirmative Action Was Wrong from the Start (Anti)
 - Stanford Magazine: The Case Against Affirmative Action (Anti...

Gun Control

- Firearm Legislation and Firearm-Related Fatalities
- Ch17 – Liberty, *Justice for Hedgehogs*
- NRA-ILA | Why Gun Control Doesn't Work
- U.S. Gun Policy: Global Comparisons | Council on Foreign...
- Do Studies Show Gun Control Works? No. – Reason.com
- For Most U.S. Gun Owners, Protection Is the Main Reason They...

Voting Rights and Gerrymandering

- Required
 - Mixed-Member Proportional Representation Explained
 - The Voting System That Actually Represents Everyone
 - Partisan Gerrymandering Mostly Cancels Out at National Level,...
 - Biggest Problem with Gerrymandering — Harvard Gazette
- Optional
 - Supreme Court Rules Partisan Gerrymandering Is Beyond The Reach...
 - What Is Extreme Gerrymandering? | Brennan Center for Justice
 - Electoral College | USAGov
 - How the Electoral College Works (PDF)

Reproductive Rights

- **Andrea Tone**, “Roe v. Wade (1973),” from *Controlling Reproduction: An American History* (1997), pp. 190–197.
 - Tone_Roe_v_Wade.pdf
- **Excerpts from *Dobbs v. Jackson Women’s Health Organization* (2022)**
 - Dobbs v. Jackson Women’s Health Organization (2022)
- **NPR**, “Abortion wasn’t always the politically charged issue it is today” (2022)
 - Abortion wasn’t always the politically charged issue it is today
- **Throughline**, “The Evangelical Vote” (2019)
 - The Evangelical Vote (2019) : Throughline : NPR
- **Diane Jackson and Jennifer Hoewe**, “Congressional Discussions of Abortion: Moral Framing in Context.” In *Partisan Rhetoric and Polarization: The Year in C-SPAN Archives Research, Volume 10*, edited by Robert X. Browning, vol. 10, Purdue University Press, 2025, pp. 89–104. JSTOR.
 - <https://doi.org/10.2307/jj.22177843.10>
- **The New York Times**, “Tracking Abortion Bans Across the Country” (updated continuously)
 - Abortion Laws Across the Country

Birthright Citizenship

Regulating AI

10 Student Privacy in Class Discussions

Draft only – we write the real one together on the first day.

What follows is where a previous section of this course landed, reproduced here as a starting point and nothing more. On August 25 we will

write our own, and whatever the class agrees to that day replaces everything below. Come ready to argue with it: the parts that look obviously right are usually the ones worth testing, and an agreement you had a hand in writing is one you might actually keep.

What this agreement is for

A discussion course works only if people will say what they actually think, and people say what they think only when they know what happens to their words afterward. That is what this agreement settles: what is on the record, what stays in the room, what may be repeated outside it and in what form. It exists to make candour possible, not to police it – which is also why you should be the ones to write it.

11 Shared Community Agreement (draft)

To foster a respectful and productive learning environment, the following policies apply:

No Recording of Class Discussions – Audio or video recording of class discussion is **not permitted**.

- Recording of lectures may be allowed with approval from **Disability Resources**.

Technology Use

- Laptops must remain closed.
- Phones must be put away unless otherwise specified.

Anonymity in Submissions

- All written work should be anonymized (**no names on papers or submissions**).
- Peer reviews will also remain anonymous.

Confidentiality of Classroom Contributions

- When discussing ideas from class outside of this setting, you may reference the **content** but not the **identities** of the individuals who contributed.

Respectful Dialogue – Listen attentively and allow peers to finish their thoughts before responding.

- Do not talk over one another.
- Treat others with the same respect you would expect for yourself.

Civility in Communication – Speak at a moderate volume.

- Critique **ideas**, not individuals.
- Assume the most generous interpretation of your peers' statements.

Use of Generative AI (GAI)

- You may not use a peer's work in generative AI tools without their **explicit permission**.
- Consider each peer's work as **copyrighted**.

Representation of Opinions

- A peer's views expressed in class do not represent the official position of their clubs, organizations, or extracurricular affiliations.

12 Course Principles

Four commitments run through the semester. They are not decoration – they are how the discussions are meant to work.

1. **Establish the fact before arguing about the cause.** Much of what everyone knows about American division turns out to be contested, mis-measured, or wrong, including by people who study it for a living. Before asking why Americans are divided we ask whether they are, how anyone would know, and what the evidence actually shows. You will read scholars disagreeing with each other over the same data, in print, by name.
2. **Division and inequality are one subject, not two.** Political conflict is not evenly costly. It shapes who is heard, who is represented, whose problems reach an agenda at all, and who absorbs the consequences of a politics organized around mutual dislike. Asking who bears those costs is the question of justice this course exists to raise, and it is not separable from the empirical work – you cannot answer it without knowing what is actually true about the divide.
3. **Institutions decide who counts.** Rules about voting, districting, representation, and speech are not neutral machinery. They distribute power, they were built by people with interests, and they can be built differently. We look at how the present arrangements came about and whom they serve.
4. **Argue with the strongest version.** You will be asked, repeatedly, to state a position you reject in terms its most serious advocate would recognize – and only then to disagree with it. This is harder than it sounds, and it is the central skill of the course. A semester spent defeating weak versions of other people's views teaches nothing at all.

By the end of this course you should be able to state what people you disagree with actually believe, in terms they would accept, and to state what you believe with reasons that survive contact with someone who does not.

13 AI Use Policy for Student Work

The rule is short: **the argument has to be yours**. Use these tools to help you work; do not use them to do the work.

Reasonable use. Brainstorming. Generating the best counter-argument to your own position so you can answer it. Checking grammar and clarity. Asking for an explanation of something in a reading you did not follow. Asking where a draft of yours is unclear.

Not reasonable. Submitting generated prose or slides as your own. Producing your discussion-board posts. Having a tool write your peer review – that one takes something from a classmate who is owed a real reader. Turning in an argument you could not defend if asked about it here, in this room, out loud.

That last test is the one that matters, and it is specific to this course. Nearly everything you write here you may be asked to say aloud: your board post seeds a discussion, your slides come with a presentation, your op-ed and your brief are positions you have taken in front of people who can question them. If you cannot say why your argument makes the move it makes, how the text got produced is beside the point. You do not have the thing the assignment was for.

Say what you used. A line at the end of the op-ed or the brief, a final slide on the book review deck, a clause in a post: *I used [tool] to [purpose]*. That is the whole requirement. Disclosure costs you nothing and is never itself a problem. Undisclosed use is.

Do not put a classmate's work into these tools without their explicit permission. Their draft is theirs, and they gave it to you to read, not to feed to something else.

Submitting generated work as your own is a violation of the university's academic integrity policy and will be handled as one. If you are unsure whether something falls inside these lines, ask me before you submit rather than after.

14 Representation Statement

I am committed to including a broad range of perspectives in the readings and materials for this course. If you believe a critical voice is missing, please let me know so I can improve the syllabus now and in future offerings.

We must treat every individual with respect. We come from many different backgrounds, and this variety of viewpoints is fundamental to building and maintaining an equitable and inclusive campus community. "Representation" can refer to the ways we identify ourselves—race, color, national origin, language, sex, disability, age, sexual orientation, gender identity, religion, creed, ancestry, belief, veteran status, or genetic information, among others. Each of these identities shapes the perspectives our students, faculty,

and staff bring to campus. Promoting these varied viewpoints not only fuels excellence and innovation but also advances the pursuit of justice. We acknowledge our imperfections while fully committing to the work—inside and outside our classrooms—of building and sustaining a campus community that embraces these core values.

Each of us is responsible for creating a safer, more inclusive environment.

Unfortunately, incidents of bias or discrimination do occur, whether intentional or unintentional. They contribute to an unwelcoming atmosphere for individuals and groups at the university. Therefore, the university encourages anyone who experiences or observes unfair or hostile treatment on the basis of identity to speak out for justice and seek support—either in the moment or afterward. You can share your experiences using the following resources:

- **Ethics Reporting Hotline**

Submit an anonymous report by calling 844-587-0793 or visiting **cmu.ethicspoint.com**.

All reports are documented and reviewed to determine whether further action is needed. Regardless of the incident type, the university will use your feedback to transform our campus climate into one that is more equitable and just.

15 Accommodations for Students with Disabilities

If you have a documented disability and an accommodations letter from the Office of Disability Resources, please discuss your needs with me as early in the semester as possible. I will work with you to ensure that accommodations are provided as appropriate. If you suspect you may have a disability and are not yet registered with the Office of Disability Resources, you can contact them at **access@andrew.cmu.edu**.

16 Student Well-Being

The past few years have been challenging. We are all under significant stress and uncertainty. I encourage you to find ways to move regularly, eat well, and reach out to your support system—or to me at **cervas@cmu.edu**—if you need help. We can all benefit from support during stressful times, and this semester is no exception.

As a student, you may experience a range of challenges that interfere with learning, such as strained relationships, increased anxiety, substance use, feeling down, difficulty concentrating, or lack of motivation. These mental health concerns or stressful events can diminish your academic performance

and reduce your ability to participate in daily activities. CMU offers services that can help, and treatment does work. Learn more about confidential mental health services available on campus at:

- **Counseling and Psychological Services:** <http://www.cmu.edu/counseling/>
Phone (24/7): 412-268-2922

Please remember that support is always available—don't hesitate to reach out.